KPPSC PMS IR Master Notes — Q3: Expansion of BRICS & SCO through Structural Realism

KPPSC PMS • INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS (100 MARKS)
Master Model Solution & Theoretical Deconstruction | 20 Marks Master Answer Guide

Executive Examination Metadata

Parameter	Specification
Target Examination	KPPSC PMS (Provincial Management Service) — Khyber Pakhtunkhwa
Paper & Subject	International Relations (100 Marks Optional — Group 6)
EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED:	• **2025 Q.3:** "Analyze the expansion of BRICS and Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) through the lens of structural realism. Are these organizations best understood as nascent challengers to a US-led liberal international order, or are their internal divisions too significant to pose a coherent alternative? (20 Marks)" • **2022 Q.8(b):** "Write short note on: Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) and Regional Integration. (10 Marks)"
Syllabus Section	Part A: Neorealism & Balance of Power | Part C: Counter-Hegemonic Blocs
Question Allocation	Attempt 1 of 5 Required (20 Marks | Strict 35-Minute Allocation)
Historiographical / Theoretical Thesis	Through Kenneth Waltz's and John Mearsheimer's structural realism, the expansion of BRICS (BRICS+) and the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) is fundamentally driven by systemic balancing against American unipolar hegemony and the weaponization of the dollar-dominated global financial architecture. However, because structural neorealism posits that anarchy breeds pervasive relative-gains concerns and security dilemmas, the profound geopolitical rivalries among member states—exemplified by the Sino-Indian border dispute and disparate strategic alignments—preclude these coalitions from forming a coherent, anti-Western military alliance, rendering them decentralized vehicles for soft institutional balancing and transactional multi-alignment.

🎯 Exam Questions Linked

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Exam Essential Takeaways

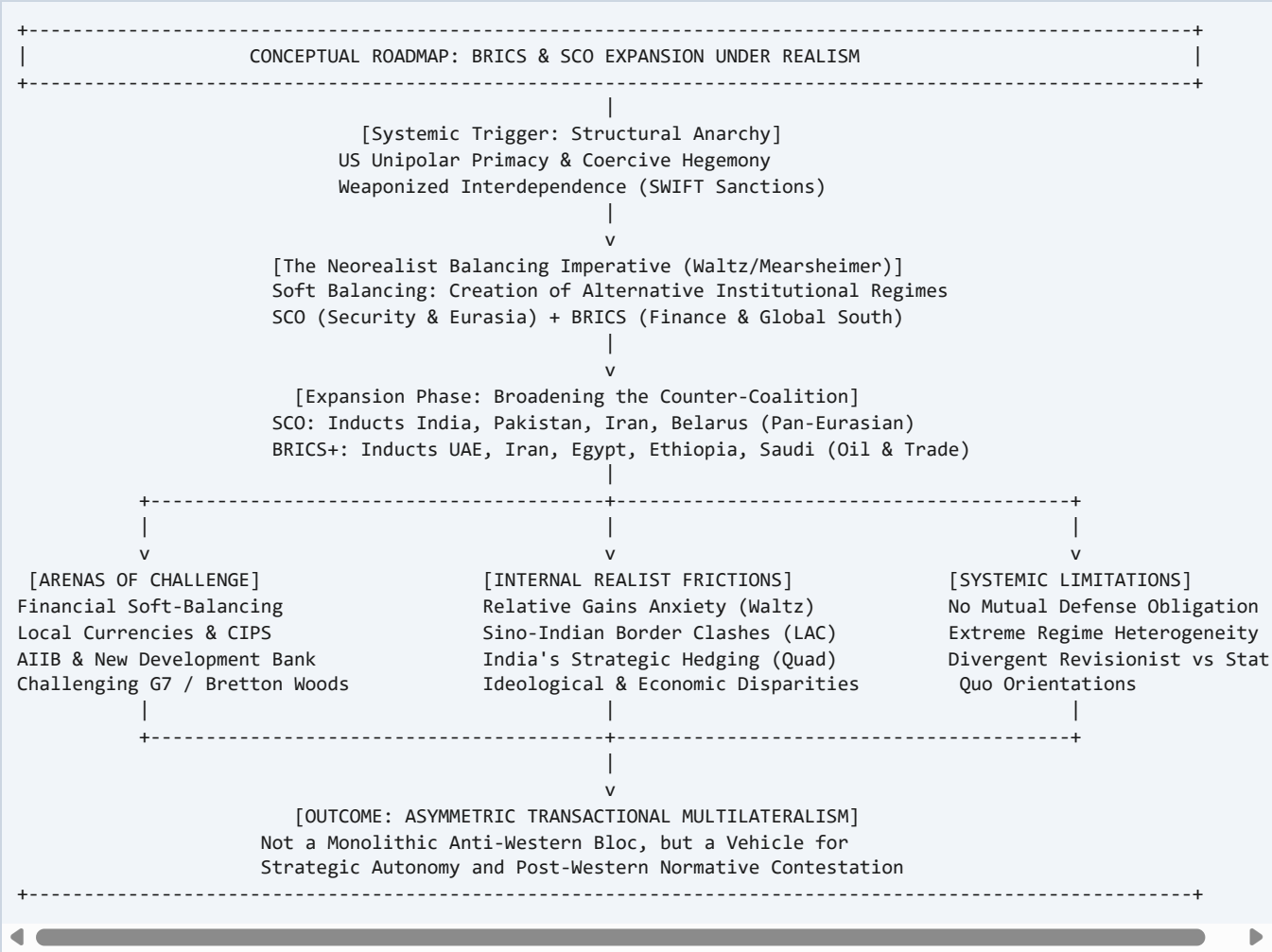
• NEOREALIST SYSTEMIC BALANCING: Neorealism dictates that excessive concentration of power (US unipolarity) triggers counter-balancing. Non-Western powers utilize BRICS and SCO as institutional soft-balancing tools to dilute Western economic and strategic primacy.

• GEO-ECONOMIC EXPANSION: The 2024 expansion of BRICS (incorporating Iran, UAE, Egypt, Ethiopia) creates an economic bloc representing ~45% of the world's population and ~40% of global crude oil production, accelerating alternative financial clearing (de-dollarization) initiatives.

• INTERNAL REALIST CONTRADICTIONS: Under Waltzian logic, states fear relative gains by partners. India's active participation in the US-led Quad while sitting in BRICS and SCO illustrates how regional security dilemmas (Sino-Indian LAC rivalry) paralyze collective bloc action.

• ABSENCE OF COLLECTIVE DEFENSE: Neither BRICS nor the SCO possesses an Article 5-style collective defense treaty. They are consultative diplomatic and geo-economic platforms, not an Eastern NATO or Warsaw Pact 2.0.

Conceptual Thematic Map & Strategic Roadmap



Analytical Dimensions & Systemic Shifts Matrix

Dimension / Arena	Strategic Mechanism / Driver	Systemic Impact on Global Order
2001: Formation of SCO	Founded in Shanghai by China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan to combat 'Three Evils'.	Established Eurasian security framework independent of Western military architecture and NATO reach.
2006–2009: Inception of BRIC(S)	First formal summit in Yekaterinburg (2009); South Africa added in 2010.	Pioneered collective economic soft-balancing demanding quota reforms in the IMF and World Bank.
2014: New Development Bank (NDB)	BRICS established NDB ($100B capital) and Contingent Reserve Arrangement (CRA).	Created parallel institutional lending architecture free of Washington Consensus conditionalities.
2017: SCO Expansion to South Asia	India and Pakistan formally inducted as full members of the SCO.	Transformed SCO into a pan-Asian platform, but embedded severe South Asian bilateral rivalries inside its institutional core.
2024: BRICS+ Landmark Expansion	Induction of Iran, UAE, Egypt, Ethiopia (with Saudi Arabia participating).	Consolidated energy-producing giants into an alternative trade clearing bloc, intensifying systemic de-dollarization pressures.

The 20-Mark Master Model Essay (~650-700 Words)

Introduction: Structural Realism and Counter-Hegemonic Balancing

The dramatic expansion of the BRICS grouping (from its original Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa core to BRICS+) and the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) represents one of the most consequential developments in contemporary international relations. In the discourse of structural realism—founded by Kenneth Waltz and extended into offensive realism by John Mearsheimer—the international system is defined by an immutable condition of anarchy, where states must rely on self-help to guarantee their survival. Neorealism posits that an extreme concentration of power, such as the post-Cold War American unipolar hegemony, inevitably generates countervailing balancing pressures. Frustrated by Western normative dominance and the coercive weaponization of dollar clearing systems (SWIFT), rising and revisionist powers have mobilized BRICS and the SCO as instruments of counter-hegemonic coordination. However, an incisive neorealist analysis reveals that while these organizations pose a formidable structural challenge to Western institutional supremacy, their acute internal divisions, relative-gains anxieties, and absence of collective defense mechanisms severely limit their capacity to function as a unified, coherent alternative bloc.

External Balancing and the Challenge to the Liberal International Order

Through the realist lens of external balancing, BRICS and the SCO represent concerted efforts to dilute Western hegemony across distinct geopolitical and geo-economic arenas. The SCO, founded in 2001, has evolved from a regional Central Asian confidence-building mechanism focused on combating the 'Three Evils' (terrorism, separatism, and extremism) into a sprawling pan-Eurasian security dialogue encompassing China, Russia, India, Pakistan, Iran, and Belarus. Concurrently, BRICS has evolved from an investment banking acronym into a formidable institutional counterweight to the G7. The 2024 expansion of BRICS to include major energy powerhouses (the UAE, Iran) and demographic anchors (Egypt, Ethiopia) creates a collective representing over 45% of the global population and nearly 40% of global oil output. By establishing the New Development Bank (NDB) and pioneering local-currency clearing systems (such as the Cross-Border Interbank Payment System, CIPS), these blocs directly contest the unilateral sanctions architecture and financial monopoly of the Bretton Woods institutions.

The Realist Dilemma: Relative Gains and Internal Strategic Fractures

Despite these outward demonstrations of collective strength, structural realism provides the exact conceptual tools to explain why BRICS and the SCO cannot operate as a cohesive anti-Western alliance. A core tenet of Waltzian realism is the 'relative-gains problem': under anarchy, states are perpetually fearful that partners will gain disproportionate power from cooperation, which could later be turned against them. This dynamic is acutely evident in the profound geopolitical chasm between China and India. The militarized confrontation along the Sino-Indian Line of Actual Control (LAC) in the Himalayas underscores an active regional security dilemma. India views China's hegemony with deep alarm; consequently, New Delhi pursues a strategy of 'multi-alignment' or strategic hedging—actively participating in the US-led Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) to balance China militarily, while concurrently attending BRICS and SCO summits to safeguard its economic interests and Global South leadership credentials.

Heterogeneity of Regimes and the Absence of Strategic Cohesion

Furthermore, the members of BRICS+ and the SCO share neither a common ideological foundation nor a shared strategic threat perception. Stephen Walt's 'Balance of Threat' theory emphasizes that states balance not merely against aggregate power, but against perceived threat and offensive intentions. Within BRICS+, members exhibit sharply divergent strategic postures: Russia and Iran represent explicitly revisionist powers locked in direct confrontation with the West, seeking to dismantle the US-led order. Conversely, states like India, Brazil, the UAE, and South Africa are status-quo reformists; they seek greater voice and prestige within global governance but remain deeply integrated into Western capital markets and have no desire to be absorbed into an anti-Western Beijing-Moscow axis. Crucially, neither BRICS nor the SCO possesses an Article 5-style collective defense clause, meaning they cannot provide hard security guarantees.

Conclusion: Asymmetric Multilateralism and the Multiplex Order

In conclusion, the expansion of BRICS and the SCO is best understood not as the embryonic emergence of an eastern Warsaw Pact, but as a manifestation of what Amitav Acharya terms the emerging 'multiplex world.' Driven by structural realist incentives to balance against unilateral US sanctions and institutional marginalization, non-Western powers are using these platforms to construct alternative, non-Western institutional options. However, because structural anarchy ensures that mutual suspicions, border disputes, and relative-gains anxieties persist within these groupings, BRICS and the SCO will remain structurally loose, transactional coalitions. They successfully accelerate the decentralization of global governance and the trend toward de-dollarization, but their internal fractures prevent them from mounting a monolithic, synchronized assault on the international system.

Theoretical Perspectives & Quotable Thesis Arguments

Theorist / Scholar	Theoretical School	Exact Quotable Thesis Argument
Kenneth N. Waltz	*Structural Realism*	"In international politics, unbalance leads to balance. When an unshared hegemony exists, weaker states will invariably balance against the dominant power to protect their sovereign autonomy."
Stephen M. Walt	*Balance of Threat Theory*	"States balance against threats, not just power. The deep internal divisions in groupings like BRICS and the SCO arise because member states like India perceive greater proximate threat from China than from distant Western hegemony."
John J. Mearsheimer	*Offensive Realism*	"Great powers are never satisfied with existing distributions of power; they seek hegemony. While China uses institutions like BRICS and the SCO to expand its sphere of influence, rival neighbors like India will inevitably hedge against Chinese dominance."
Amitav Acharya	*Post-Western International Relations*	"BRICS and the SCO do not represent a new Cold War bloc, but the rise of a multiplex world—an order featuring multiple modernities, diverse regional architectures, and overlapping cross-alignments rather than rigid bipolar alliances."
C. Raja Mohan	*Strategic Multi-Alignment*	"India's simultaneous presence in the Quad and BRICS/SCO is not an ideological contradiction, but the quintessential realist strategy of multi-alignment: extracting benefits from the West while preserving leverage in Eurasia."